EXCELLENCE VOICES

DEBATE COMPETITION

2026

Empowering Young Voices

About This Booklet

This booklet presents debate topics connected with everyday experiences at school, at home, in the community, and online. Each topic includes a short context to help participants understand the issue and prepare their own opinions.

A good debate is not only about winning. It is about explaining a viewpoint clearly, supporting it with examples, listening respectfully, and responding thoughtfully to the other side.

How to Prepare

1. **Understand the motion:** Be clear about the question and the possible positions.
2. **Build your case:** Prepare two or three main points and support them with real-life examples.
3. **Anticipate the other side:** Think about what the opposing speaker may say and how you could respond respectfully.
4. **Speak clearly:** Use a short introduction, organised points, and a strong conclusion.
5. **Respect others:** Challenge ideas, not people. Listen carefully and avoid interrupting.

Suggested Speaking Structure

Opening statement → Main argument 1 → Main argument 2 with examples → Response to the opposing side → Conclusion.

Debate Topics for Practice

The context under each topic is a starting point, not a ready-made speech. Participants should prepare arguments for both sides.

1. Mobile Phones: Useful or Harmful for Students?

Should students be allowed to use mobile phones, or do phones distract them from their studies? Discuss learning apps, communication, screen time, concentration, and responsible use.

2. Social Media: A Blessing or a Curse?

Does social media help people learn, share ideas, and stay connected, or can it waste time and affect confidence? Consider friendships, cyberbullying, privacy, and online learning.

3. Homework: Necessary for Learning or an Unnecessary Burden?

Does homework strengthen classroom learning, or should students have more time for hobbies, family, and rest? Consider practice, independent learning, stress, and workload.

4. Exams: The Best Way to Measure Intelligence?

Do exam marks show what a person truly knows, or should creativity, practical skills, teamwork, and communication count more? Discuss what exams measure well and what they may miss.

5. Artificial Intelligence: Helpful or Risky for Students?

Does AI make learning easier, or can depending on it weaken independent thinking? Consider fact-checking, originality, responsible use, and learning by doing.

6. School Uniforms: Should They Be Compulsory?

Do uniforms encourage equality, identity, and discipline, or should students have more freedom to choose what they wear? Discuss cost, comfort, self-expression, and rules.

7. Online Learning vs Classroom Learning: Which Is Better?

Can online classes offer flexibility and useful digital resources, or does face-to-face learning provide better interaction and focus? Consider access, distractions, feedback, and friendships.

8. Sports vs Studies: Which Should Students Prioritise?

Should academic work come first, or are sports just as important? Discuss health, teamwork, time management, academic goals, and balance.

9. Reading Books vs Watching Educational Videos

Which helps people understand and remember information better? Compare reading, imagination, vocabulary, visual explanations, attention, and different learning styles.

10. Should Students Have a Say in School Rules?

Should school rules be decided only by teachers and management, or should students help shape some of them? Discuss student voice, safety, discipline, fairness, and responsibility.

11. Competition vs Cooperation: What Helps People Succeed?

Does competition motivate people to improve, or does cooperation help everyone learn and achieve more? Use examples from group projects, workplaces, sports, and peer support.

12. Communication Skills vs Academic Marks: Which Matters More?

Are high marks enough for success, or are speaking, listening, teamwork, and confidence equally important? Consider interviews, presentations, exams, and everyday communication.

13. Is Failure More Valuable Than Success?

Can failure teach patience, problem-solving, and resilience in ways success may not, or should the main focus be on achieving goals? Consider how mistakes can help people learn.

14. Should Young People Have More Responsibilities at Home?

Do household tasks build independence and life skills, or can too many duties interfere with study and rest? Discuss age-appropriate tasks and sharing responsibilities fairly.

15. A Life Without Smartphones: Better or Worse?

Would life without smartphones improve focus, sleep, and face-to-face conversation, or would people lose useful tools for learning, safety, and communication? Consider both sides.

Recommended Topics for the Competition

These topics are especially engaging because they invite participants to use real-life examples, reason carefully, and respond to opposing arguments.

1. Should Students Have a Say in School Rules?

Encourages respectful discussion about fairness, discipline, student voice, and responsibility.

2. Communication Skills vs Academic Marks: Which Matters More?

Connects with confidence, presentations, interviews, and everyday communication.

3. Artificial Intelligence: Helpful or Risky for Students?

Offers arguments about learning, independent thinking, and responsible technology use.

4. Competition vs Cooperation: What Helps People Succeed?

Invites examples from teamwork, friendships, sports, and shared goals.

5. Is Failure More Valuable Than Success?

Encourages personal stories, resilience, problem-solving, and motivational conclusions.

Guidance for Trainers

Assign opposing positions rather than allowing every participant to choose only the side they personally agree with. For example, a participant who believes AI is helpful should also practise arguing that AI can be risky. Encourage participants to use examples, organise their points, listen carefully, and respond respectfully. This develops reasoning, confidence, rebuttal skills, and spontaneous speaking.